

Teacher: Mr. Washington	Grade(s): 1	Total # Students: 20	# ELL/MLLs: 7
Content Area: ELA	Date / Lesson Length: 4/20/26		
Program Model: <i>(indicate)</i> Pull-out / Push-in / Integrated Content / Sheltered Content / Dual Language / Transitional Bilingual: Push-in			

CONTENT & RATIONALE:

Across the lesson sequence, students will progress from identifying topics using visuals to independently determining the main idea and supporting details within short texts. Instruction will include explicit modeling, think-aloud strategies, collaborative conversations, and guided practice. Students will use structured sentence frames such as “The main topic is ____” and “A detail that supports this is ____” to support both oral language development and content understanding.

This unit is designed using culturally responsive pedagogy and Communicative Language Teaching to support Entering ENL 1st-grade students in developing both content knowledge and academic English. Identifying main topics and supporting details is a foundational reading comprehension skill that directly supports future literacy development across grade levels.

Think-alouds and teacher modeling make invisible reading processes visible, helping students understand how proficient readers determine meaning. Sentence frames and structured oral interaction reduce language barriers and promote meaningful participation, ensuring students can engage with grade-level content even at early English proficiency levels.

ESSENTIAL QUESTIONS / FOCUS QUESTIONS:

What is the text mostly about?

How do details help us understand the topic?

How can I explain what I read?

CONTENT & SKILLS STANDARDS:

RL.1.2 – Retell stories, including key details, and demonstrate understanding of the central message or lesson.

RI.1.2 – Identify the main topic and retell key details of a text.

RI.1.1 – Ask and answer questions about key details in a text.

TESOL / [WIDA](#) Standards:

WIDA Standard 1: Language for Social and Instructional Purposes

WIDA Standard 2: Language for Language Arts

CONTENT, what will students KNOW?		SKILLS, what will students DO?	
NYS Next Generation	- Retell stories, including key details, and demonstrate understanding of the central message or lesson.	NYS Next Generation	- Students will build understanding of how informational texts are organized (main topic vs. supporting details).

Learning Standards (Math & ELA):	- Students will know how to identify the main topic of an informational text and recognize supporting key details.	Learning Standards (Math & ELA):	- Students will understand that visuals and text work together to convey meaning.
CONTENT STANDARDS (Science or Social Studies):	- Students will develop an understanding of how weather and environmental conditions affect different places on Earth, including deserts.	CONTENT STANDARDS (Science or Social Studies):	- Students will identify the main topic and retell key details from an informational text using oral and/or visual responses.

LEARNER OUTCOMES / OBJECTIVES:

- **Content:** *Students will identify what a “main topic” is.*
- **Language:** *Students will say, “The main topic is ____.”*
- **Literacy:**
 - *Reading comprehension: identifying main topic using visuals*
 - *Listening & speaking: turn-and-talk using sentence frames*
 - *Vocabulary: introduction to “main topic” and “details”*
 - *Emerging understanding of key details through images*

TEXTS & MATERIALS:

Arnold, Q. M. (2017). *Deserts*. Creative Paperbacks.

ACTIVITIES FORMAT: Indicate by entering X

Grouping		Scaffolding		Processes	
Entire Class	X	Modeling	X	Reading	X
Small group	X	Individual	X	Listening	X
Partners	X	Guided	X	Writing	X
Individual	X			Speaking	X

PROCEDURE:

To begin the lesson, I will activate students' prior knowledge by displaying a set of large, high-quality images of different environments such as deserts, oceans, and forests. I will point to each image and model curiosity by saying, “Hmm... I see a lot of sand here. I see sun and no water. I wonder what this place is mostly about?” I will intentionally pause after each question to give students time to think, then prompt them to turn and talk with a partner using the sentence starter, “I see ____.” After partner sharing, I will bring the class back together and explicitly introduce the concept of the main **topic**. I will say, “Today we are learning something important readers do. Readers figure out the *main topic*. That means what the picture or story is mostly about.” I will model this using one image (the desert) and think aloud step-by-step: “I see sand, I see heat, I see very few plants. All of these details help me think.. this is about a desert.” As I model, I will intentionally point to each visual detail and connect it back to the idea of “what it is mostly about,” so students can see how thinking is connected to evidence. I will then restate the concept slowly and clearly, using gestures: “Main topic = what it is mostly about.” Next, students will practice in pairs. I'd give them a new image and guide them by circulating the room, prompting students with questions like, “What do you see?” and “What is this mostly about?” If students struggle, I will scaffold by offering choices (“Is it the ocean or the desert?”) and repeating key vocabulary. I will also encourage students to use the sentence frame: “The main topic is ____.” During the activity, I will actively circulate, listen for language use, and gently

reformulate student responses by restating them in full academic sentences. For example, if a student says “sand,” I will respond, “Yes, the main topic is the desert because we see sand and heat.” To close the lesson, I will bring students back together and check their understanding by asking, “What does the main topic mean?” and “What is one thing we learned today?” Students will respond orally using sentence frames such as, “The main topic is ____.” I will reinforce learning by restating correct responses and connecting them back to the day’s goal. Throughout the lesson, I will use visuals, repetition, gestures, and structured partner talk to ensure Entering ENL students can fully access the concept while still engaging in meaningful academic language use.

BEFORE READING/WRITING (INTO)

Pre-Assessment / Prior Knowledge:

In previous lessons, students engaged in activities involving picture description, vocabulary building related to environments (e.g., sand, hot, water, animals), and basic oral language practice through turn-and-talk routines. These experiences helped build foundational academic vocabulary and comfort with collaborative speaking routines, but students have not yet been formally introduced to identifying main topic and key details as an academic reading skill.

Warm-Up / Building Background / Activating Schema / Vocabulary:

To begin the lesson, I will capture students’ attention by displaying a large, engaging image of a desert and asking, “What do you see?” Students will participate in a quick turn-and-talk using the sentence frame, “I see ____.” I will use a countdown and hand signal to bring the class back together. To motivate students, I will introduce the lesson as a “reading detective” activity, explaining that they will figure out what something is mostly about. I will connect to prior lessons by reminding students that they have practiced describing pictures, and now they will use those skills to understand a bigger idea. I will activate prior knowledge by asking guiding questions and building on student responses. Then, I will introduce key vocabulary: main topic (“what it is mostly about”) and detail (“small things we see or learn”), using visuals, gestures, and repetition. Students will repeat the words and demonstrate understanding through simple responses. This approach engages students, connects to prior learning, and prepares them with the vocabulary needed for the lesson.

DURING READING/WRITING (THROUGH)

Interacting with the Text / Close Reading / Teacher Modeling / Guided Practice:

As I introduce the text or image, I will model a thought-aloud: “I see sand and sun, I’m thinking about what this is mostly about, this is a desert.” I will point to visuals to make my thinking clear. I will guide students with questions like, “What do you see?” and “What is this mostly about?” Students will first turn and talk using the sentence frame, “The main topic is ____,” then share aloud. I will pause often to check understanding using thumbs up/down and either/or questions (e.g., “Ocean or desert?”). I will reinforce vocabulary by contrasting the main topic (big idea) and detail (small parts), and expand student responses into complete sentences. This supports both comprehension and language development through modeling, questioning, and interaction.

AFTER READING/WRITING (BEYOND)

Follow-up Activity / Independent or Group Practice:

To reinforce learning, I will review key vocabulary (main topic and detail) and have students restate their ideas using sentence frames like, “The main topic is ____.” To extend learning, students will apply the skill to a new image with a partner, while I circulate and ask questions like, “How do you know?” To enrich understanding, students will connect the concept to their own experiences and, if ready, add a supporting detail. This supports reinforcement while building independence and language use.

ADAPTATIONS / ACCOMMODATIONS in SUPPORT STRATEGIES FOR DIVERSE LEARNERS:

Due to students being at the entering proficiency level, they will use visuals, gestures, and single-word responses (e.g., “desert”) supported by repetition and modeling. Sentence frames will be simplified (e.g., “Main topic: ____”).

Strategy: Visual scaffolding + modeling.

Why: Supports comprehension when language is limited.

Types of Strategies:

- Cognitive Strategies
- Metacognitive Strategies
- Language Learning Strategies

STRATEGY USED	STRATEGY CITATION	STUDENTS THIS STRATEGY SUPPORTS
Repetition and modeling	Baker, C., & Wright, W. E. (2021). <i>Foundations of Bilingual Education and Bilingualism</i> (7th ed.). Multilingual Matters.	Entering - Transitioning
Sentence frames for structured language use	Baker, C., & Wright, W. E. (2021). <i>Foundations of Bilingual Education and Bilingualism</i> (7th ed.). Multilingual Matters.	Entering - Transitioning
Visual scaffolding	Echevarría, J., Vogt, M., & Short, D. (2017). <i>Making Content Comprehensible for English Learners: The SIOP Model</i> (5th ed.). Pearson.	Entering - Transitioning

SOCIAL-EMOTIONAL LEARNING / STRATEGIES SUPPORT:

To support SEL, I will begin with a quick emotional check-in using visuals or thumbs up/down to build self-awareness. During the lesson, students will engage in structured turn-and-talk activities to practice social awareness and relationship skills, including listening, taking turns, and responding respectfully. I will model positive interactions and reinforce respectful behavior throughout the lesson. Clear routines and expectations will support responsible decision-making and help students feel safe participating and taking risks with language.

ASSESSMENT / EVALUATION:

Student learning will be measured through ongoing formative assessments that directly align with the lesson’s content and language objectives. I will use both oral responses and structured partner interactions to determine whether students can identify the main topic and use academic language to explain their thinking. Success will be determined by students’ ability to identify a main topic (even with support), recognize at least one supporting detail, and attempt oral academic language using sentence frames during structured interaction.

Objective	Assessment / Measurement	Description
Content	Oral responses during whole-class discussion and turn-and-talk	Students will identify the main topic of the image/text and provide at least one supporting detail with teacher support. The teacher will assess understanding through questioning and observation.
Language	Sentence frame participation	Students will use sentence frames such as “The main topic is ____.” during partner and class discussions. The teacher will monitor students’ ability to use academic vocabulary and structured oral language.
Literacy	Observation of comprehension and vocabulary use	Students will demonstrate emerging reading comprehension skills by recognizing key details in visuals/text and connecting them to the main topic. The teacher will assess listening comprehension, vocabulary understanding, and participation in discussions.

REVIEW & CLOSURE:

To end the lesson, I will revisit the objective by asking students what the main topic and detail are. Students will respond using sentence frames such as, “*The main topic is ____.*” I will briefly review the desert image and restate how the details helped us figure out the main topic. This reinforces the connection between visuals, details, and main idea. Finally, I will praise student effort and restate the learning goal to ensure students understand how to identify a main topic using supporting details.

HOME / COMMUNITY LITERACY CONTEXTS:

To extend learning beyond the classroom, students will be encouraged to talk with a family member about what they learned using simple language or their home language. They will describe a place they know (such as a park, beach, or neighborhood) and explain what it is mostly about using the idea of a “main topic.” Students may share drawings of the desert or another environment and explain it to a family member using sentence frames like, “*This is a ____.*” This allows students to reinforce understanding of the main topic and details through meaningful real-world conversation and home connection, rather than a traditional written homework task.